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DESIGN CODE NS 08

Ember the Baby Dragon

US crochet terms · Intermediate · 4-5 hours

A chunky, big-headed baby dragon with a stubby snout, scalloped wings and a ridge of spikes down the back. Fantasy amigurumi carries the highest price point of any category in this set, and the detail is what justifies it.

Ember **sits** — she is not a standing animal. Her body rests on the table, her back legs fold under her as haunches and her front legs splay forward.

MATERIALS

Main yarn — Worsted #4, about 50 g. Sage green, dusty teal, lilac or charcoal.

Belly and wings — Worsted #4, about 20 g in a contrast cream or pale gold.

Spikes — Worsted #4, about 10 g in the contrast color.

Hook — 3.5 mm (US E/4).

Eyes — 2 × 10 mm safety eyes. Slit-pupil dragon eyes if you can get them.

Also needed — Polyester fiber fill, about 10 g; tapestry needle; stitch markers; pins.

The yarn figures are working amounts, not measured consumption. Ember herself uses well under 10 g of the main color; the rest allows for tails, sewing, swatching and a second attempt.

Safety. Ember uses 10 mm safety eyes, which are a small part and a choking hazard. She is a decorative piece, not a toy for young children, and she has not been tested to a toy-safety standard such as ASTM F963 or EN 71. If you want to give her to a child, embroider the eyes instead and check every seam first.

GAUGE

Worsted #4 on a 3.5 mm hook: about **4.5 mm per stitch** and **4.3 mm per round**.

Check it on the body after Rnd 5 — 30 stitches should measure about 43 mm around. Every measurement in this pattern follows from that gauge. If your stitches are wider than 4.5 mm, crochet more tightly or drop to a 3.0 mm hook, or the stuffing will show through.

FINISHED SIZE

About **11 cm (4.3 in) tall seated**, with a **12.5 cm (5 in) wingspan** and a **5 cm (2 in) tail**.

Body, Rnd 1 to Rnd 13	13 rnd × 4.3 mm = 56 mm
Head, Rnd 1 to Rnd 11	11 rnd × 4.3 mm = 47 mm
Seated height	about 103 mm ≈ 11 cm
Wing, straight edge	10 sts × 4.5 mm = 45 mm
Wingspan	45 + 34 + 45 = about 124 mm ≈ 12.5 cm
Tail	12 rnd × 4.3 mm = 52 mm ≈ 5 cm

If you want a larger dragon, the body and the head both need about 18 rounds each rather than 13 and 11 — that is what takes the seated height to roughly 16 cm. Everything else in this pattern scales with them.

ABBREVIATIONS

MR	magic ring
ch	chain
sc	single crochet
hdc	half double crochet
dc	double crochet
inc	increase — 2 sc in one stitch
dec	invisible decrease
sl st	slip stitch
FO	fasten off
(n)	the stitch count at the end of that round

WORKING NOTES

Work in a **continuous spiral** unless a row says to turn. Mark the first stitch of every round — in a spiral there is no join to count from.

The wings and the spike strip are the exceptions: both are worked **flat, in turned rows**.

Unless a note says otherwise, work every stitch through both loops.

HOW IT COMES TOGETHER

The core techniques, in the order you meet them.

1 • The magic ring. Every piece begins with a magic ring. Pull the tail tight once the first round is complete.

2 • Work in a spiral. Keep a stitch marker in the first stitch of every round.

3 • Matched open joins. Ember's head and her neck are both left open at **18 stitches**, so the two edges are the same size and can be ladder-stitched together cleanly. This is the single most important structural detail in the pattern — the head is heavy, and this joint carries all of it.

1 • HEAD — main color, make 1

A big head is what makes a dragon read as a baby dragon. Two straight rounds only, then the decreases.

The head is worked **top-down** and is **left open**. Do not close it.

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS	NOTE
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	
R2	inc in each st around	(12)	
R3	[sc, inc] ×6	(18)	
R4	[2 sc, inc] ×6	(24)	
R5	[3 sc, inc] ×6	(30)	
R6	[4 sc, inc] ×6	(36)	head at full width
R7	sc in each st around	(36)	eyes go on R7–R8
R8	sc in each st around	(36)	
R9	[4 sc, dec] ×6	(30)	
R10	[3 sc, dec] ×6	(24)	stuff firmly
R11	[2 sc, dec] ×6	(18)	leave open — matches the neck

Finish. Stuff the head firmly. **Do not fasten off and do not close it.** The open 18-stitch edge is sewn to the body's neck. Leave a long tail if you prefer to sew rather than join as you go.

This is where the original shape of the pattern was weakest. Closing the head down to 6 stitches leaves a gathered point about 9 mm across, and sewing that to a 26 mm neck ring is a small seam carrying a heavy head — which is exactly why a dragon's head flops. Stopping at 18 stitches gives the two pieces edges that match, and the join becomes strong.

2 · SNOUT — main color, make 1

Sewn to the front of the head. A dragon without a projecting snout reads as a bear.

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)
R2	[sc, inc] ×3	(9)
R3	[2 sc, inc] ×3	(12)
R4	sc in each st around	(12)
R5	sc in each st around	(12)

Finish. FO with a long tail. Stuff lightly.

Pin the snout centered on **Rnds 8-11** of the head, just below the eye line, and sew all the way around. It must project past the curve of the head, not sit flush with it. Embroider two small nostrils at the tip once it is attached.

3 · BODY — main color, make 1

Worked bottom-up. The neck is left open so the head can be seated on it.

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS	NOTE
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	
R2	inc in each st around	(12)	
R3	[sc, inc] ×6	(18)	
R4	[2 sc, inc] ×6	(24)	tail attaches at R4-R6
R5	[3 sc, inc] ×6	(30)	body at full width —
R6	sc in each st around	(30)	check gauge here
R7	sc in each st around	(30)	back legs attach at R6
R8	sc in each st around	(30)	front legs attach at R8
R9	sc in each st around	(30)	
R10	[3 sc, dec] ×6	(24)	wings attach at
R11	sc in each st around	(24)	R10-R11
R12	[2 sc, dec] ×6	(18)	stuff firmly
R13	sc in each st around	(18)	leave the neck OPEN

Finish. FO with a 40 cm tail. Do not close. Pack the neck firmly before you join the head — a soft neck is what lets the head flop forward.

4 · LEGS — main color

Make 2 back legs (6 rounds) and 2 front legs (8 rounds).

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS	WHICH LEGS
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	all four
R2	[sc, inc] ×3	(9)	all four
R3	sc in each st around	(9)	all four
R4	sc in each st around	(9)	all four
R5	sc in each st around	(9)	all four
R6	sc in each st around	(9)	all four — back legs
R7	sc in each st around	(9)	finish here
R8	sc in each st around	(9)	front legs only
			front legs only

Finish. Stuff the lower half of each leg lightly. Flatten the top 3 stitches. FO with a long tail.

The two pairs are **not** the same length, and that is deliberate. The back legs attach at Rnd 6, which is 26 mm above the body's base; the front legs attach at Rnd 8, 34 mm up. A leg attached higher has to be longer for its foot to reach the same level:

	rounds	length	attaches	foot reaches
back	6	26 mm	26 mm up	the table
front	8	34 mm	34 mm up	the table

Make all four the same length and the back feet end up 9 mm lower than the front ones, so Ember rocks back onto her haunches with her front feet in the air.

Sew the back legs to **Rnd 6** and the front legs to **Rnd 8**, about **8 stitches apart** on each pair. Angle the back legs under her as haunches and the front legs slightly forward. Ember's body rests on the table; the legs support the pose rather than lifting her off it.

5 · TAIL — main color, make 1

Worked from the tip up, so it tapers naturally.

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS
R1	4 sc in MR	(4)
R2	sc in each st around	(4)
R3	[sc, inc] ×2	(6)
R4	sc in each st around	(6)
R5	sc in each st around	(6)
R6	[2 sc, inc] ×2	(8)
R7	sc in each st around	(8)
R8	sc in each st around	(8)
R9	[3 sc, inc] ×2	(10)
R10	sc in each st around	(10)
R11	sc in each st around	(10)
R12	sc in each st around	(10)

Finish. Stuff lightly. FO with a long tail. Flatten the open end and sew it to the back of the body at **Rnds 4-6**.

6 · HORNS — contrast color, make 2

RND	INSTRUCTION	STS
R1	4 sc in MR	(4)
R2	sc in each st around	(4)
R3	[sc, inc] ×2	(6)
R4	sc in each st around	(6)
R5	sc in each st around	(6)

Finish. Do not stuff. FO with a long tail. Sew to the crown of the head, **6 stitches apart**, angled back.

7 · WINGS — contrast color, make 2

Worked flat, in turned rows, then finished with a scalloped edge. Every row consumes exactly the stitches the row before it produced.

Ch 11.

Row 1. From the 2nd ch from the hook: sc in 4, hdc in 3, dc in 3. Ch 1, turn. **[10]**

Row 2. sc in 3, hdc in 3, dc in 4. Ch 1, turn. **[10]**

Row 3. sc in 2, hdc in 4, dc in 4. Ch 1, turn. **[10]**

Row 4 — scalloped edge. sl st in the first 2, (**sc, hdc, dc, hdc, sc**) in the next st, sl st in the next 2, (**sc, hdc, dc, hdc, sc**) in the next st, sl st in the last 4.

Finish. FO with a 25 cm tail.

The slip-stitch groups are **2 / 2 / 4** — eight stitches — which with the two shells, worked into one stitch each, consumes all 10 stitches of Row 3. Nothing is left over. Both scallops are identical, so the two ends of the wing match.

Pin the straight inner edge of each wing to the back of the body across **Rnds 10-11**, about **8 stitches apart**, angled up and out. Sew along the whole straight edge so the scalloped edge stays free — sewing only the top corner is what makes a wing droop.

8 · BACK SPIKES — contrast color, make 1

One continuous strip, sewn down the center back from the crown of the head to the tip of the tail. Nine spikes: 3 on the head, 4 on the body, 2 on the tail.

Ch 4.

Row 1. sc in the 2nd ch from the hook. Then work this group **9 times**:

ch 4, sl st in the 2nd ch from the hook, sc in the next ch, hdc in the next ch.

Each group makes one spike, and the last stitch of each group is also where the next one begins — so the nine spikes form one continuous ridge with no gaps.

Then **sc in the next 2**, and **FO with a long tail**.

The finished strip is **30 stitches** — 1 at the start, 3 for each of the 9 spikes, 2 at the end — and roughly **13.5 cm long**. That is a little under the 15.5 cm crown-to-tail path, which is what you want: the strip follows a curve over the head, down the back and along the tail, and it should go on slightly snug rather than stretched. If it will not reach, work one more spike.

Each spike is a small cone. Chaining 4 and working back along it with a slip stitch, a single and a half double makes a point about 10 mm long, and about 13 mm of the strip is taken up by each one. Nine of them plus the ends come to roughly 148 mm.

The spikes deliberately touch. A dragon's spine is a continuous ridge, and any plain stitches you add between them make the strip too long for the path — each extra single crochet adds about 4.5 mm.

Check the length before you sew. Pin the strip from the crown down the back to the tail tip. If it runs long, unpick from the plain end; if it runs short, work one more spike, which adds about 13.5 mm. Sewing it slightly stretched or slightly gathered is visible from across the room, so get this right before the first stitch.

9 · ASSEMBLY

Work in this order. Each step is easier before the next one is in the way.

- 1. Snout to head**, centered on Rnds 8-11, below the eye line.
- 2. Eyes** between Rnds 7 and 8, **8 stitches apart**, just above the snout. Fit the washers before the head is joined to the body — once it is closed up you cannot reach inside.
- 3. Horns** to the crown, 6 stitches apart, angled back.
- 4. Head to body.** Both edges are open at 18 stitches. Seat the head on the neck and **ladder-stitch all the way around, then make a second pass and pull it tight**. Pack the neck firmly first. This joint carries the whole head.
- 5. Legs** — back pair to Rnd 6, front pair to Rnd 8, angled as described.
- 6. Tail** to the back of the body at Rnds 4-6.
- 7. Wings** across Rnds 10-11.
- 8. Spike strip last**, pinned from crown to tail tip before you sew a stitch.

TROUBLESHOOTING

Head flops forward — Two causes, and both are about the join. Pack the neck firmly before you close it, and make the second ladder-stitch pass tight. If the head still moves, the two edges did not match: both the head and the neck must be open at 18 stitches.

Ember rocks back onto her haunches — All four legs are the same length, and they cannot be. The back legs attach 26 mm up and the front legs 34 mm up, so equal-length legs leave the back feet 9 mm lower. Work the back legs 6 rounds and the front legs 8.

Ember will not sit — The legs are sewn too high, or the body is under-stuffed at the base. Back legs belong on Rnd 6 and front legs on Rnd 8, and the lower body needs to be firm enough to sit on.

Wings droop — Sew along the whole straight inner edge, not just the top corner.

Spike strip curves — Pin the entire strip from crown to tail before you sew a single stitch. This is the most visible seam on the toy.

Spike strip is the wrong length — The strip is worked from a 40-chain foundation, which suits this gauge. If your chains are looser it will run long; unpick from the plain end rather than stretching it to fit.

Looks like a bear — The snout is missing or under-stuffed. It must project past the dome of the head.

Stuffing shows through — Your gauge is too loose. Thirty stitches should measure 43 mm around the body. Crochet more tightly, or go down to a 3.0 mm hook.

COLORWAYS

Sage green, dusty teal, lilac, charcoal and blush pink all sell well. Jewel tones photograph best against a pale background.

BEFORE YOU ASSEMBLE

Lay every component out and check it against the pattern before you sew anything:

- 1 head, open at 18 stitches
- 1 snout
- 1 body, neck open at 18 stitches
- 2 back legs of 6 rounds, 2 front legs of 8 rounds
- 1 tail
- 2 horns
- 2 wings
- 1 spike strip with 9 spikes

Pin each piece and look at Ember from the front before committing a single stitch.

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